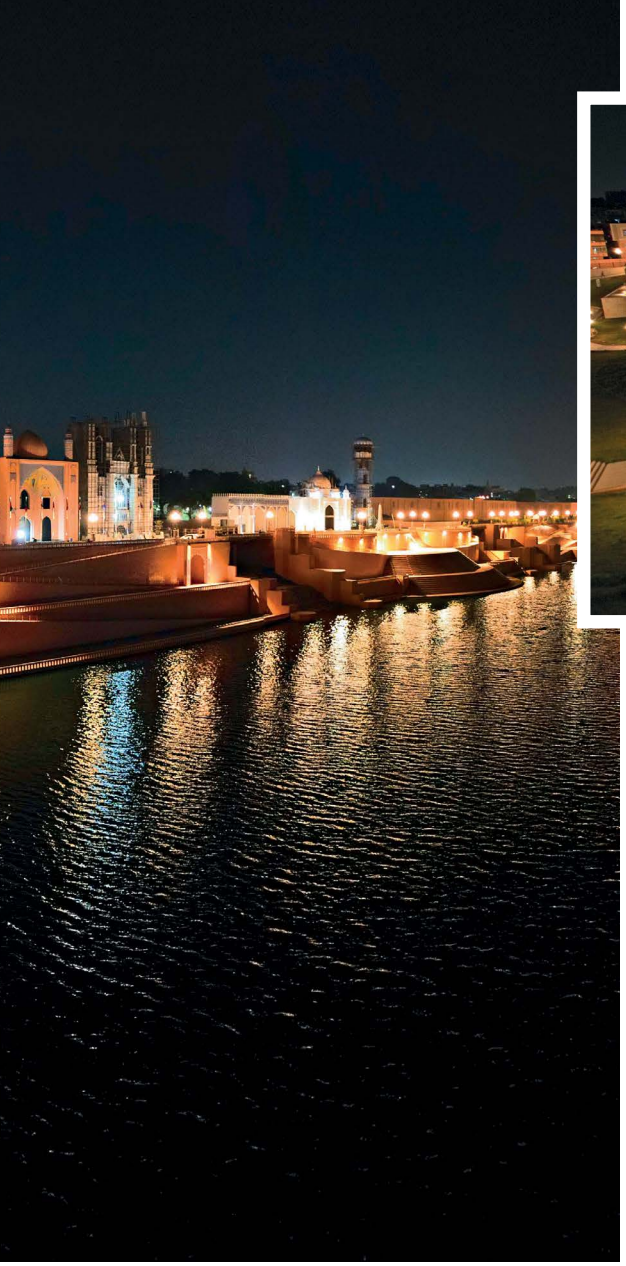




BILL OF DEVELOPMENT
The beautified Chambal riverfront in Kota

A helical clover bridge sounds like a sleek thing right out of some First World xanadu. This one, built at a cost of Rs 42 crore, is in Rajasthan's Kota, but it soars and twists balletically too, for about a kilometre, except that it lands a few metres from where it started. Even more mystifyingly, it soars over nothing: there's no crossing or rail track or any form of obstruction underneath. Just a few minutes away, along the Chambal, a new riverfront was inaugurated with great pomp on September 12—a costly façade laid end-to-end over three kilometres of natural rock and soil like a pink stone shroud, leaving not even parts of the riverbed, let alone a scrap of greenery. In its place have come up 26 spanking new ghats strung along imitation Rajputana architectural chic. Turrets and chhatris in the local Hadauti style. An army of giant statues, one of which, a 25-feet Yogimudra, vanishes when you see it straight on. Another curiosity is both visible and audible: the world's largest bell whose boom, they say, can be heard eight kilometres away and, coming in at 82 tonnes on the scale, is no bantamweight either. Goddess Chambal, a deity who's considered cursed and hence is rarely worshipped, also gets a 242-feet-high statue of Vietnamese marble here. The riverfront is studded liberally with replicas that stand like displaced metaphors, such as a highrise Red Fort or the Chinese Pagoda. Add a proposed boat cruise, a water park, a train on tyres, golf carts, skating area, the world's second-largest musical fountain, cafes, restaurants, a commercial complex... in short, it's the full fairground cornucopia. Kota (North) MLA and Rajasthan urban development minister Shanti Dhariwal, whose brainchild this frenzied beautification is, wanted to outdo the Kashi Corridor and the Sabarmati riverfront and take Kota right into the elite club of Paris and London. Dumb-struck critics call it the "world's only copycat heritage waterfront".

The state government, keen to eke out any form of publicity in the run-up to the assembly election, has already spent over Rs 1,400 crore on the project, and another Rs 1,200 crore has been planned for its second phase. This despite recent allegations that Kota's Urban Improvement Trust and the state urban development department did not obtain the necessary environmental clearances for the project, which falls within the eco-sensitive zone (ESZ) of the National Chambal Ghariyal Sanctuary. In fact, a July letter from the Centre to the Rajasthan government, which was brought to light by ex-MLA Prahlad Gunjal a day before the inauguration, had asked the state to take necessary action. Amid these storm signals, Chief Minister Ashok Gehlot announced hours before the riverfront's unveiling that he would not be attending the inauguration ceremony.

But the Chambal riverfront is not the only project over which money has been spent like water.